Medical News in Brief

Meta-Analysis: Most Effective Exercises for Reducing Blood Pressure

Isometric exercises, which involve contracting muscles to hold the body in position without moving, are best for lowering resting blood pressure, according to results from 270 randomized clinical trials involving 15 827 participants. After isometric exercises, which include activities such as wall squats, combined training tended to reduce blood pressure the most, followed by dynamic resistance training, aerobic exercise, and high-intensity interval training (HIIT).

Existing guidelines, which are based on older research and don't include data from new forms of exercise such as HIIT, tend to emphasize aerobic training such as running for controlling blood pressure. In addition to helping clinicians optimize individualized exercise recommendations, the new findings suggest that it might be time to update exercise guidelines for preventing and treating high blood pressure, the researchers wrote in the *British Journal of Sports Medicine*.

Published Online: August 2, 2023.
doi:10.1001/jama.2023.13616

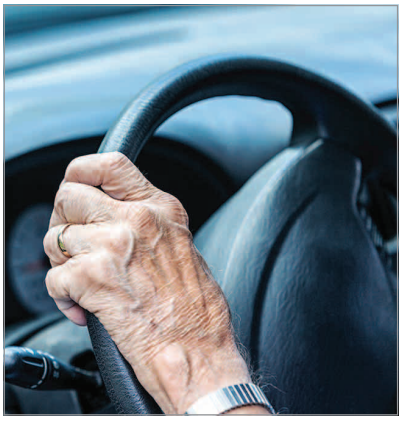
Many Older People With Cognitive Impairment Continue Driving

More than 60% of older adults with cognitive impairment are still driving, despite about 36% of their caregivers reporting safety concerns, according to results from 635 participants aged 65 years or older.

The majority of caregivers also expressed feeling that the people they cared for should avoid driving at night, in the rain, or in busy traffic.

Conversations about retiring from driving can be challenging because they touch on sensitive areas such as loss of autonomy and changes in caregiving burden, the researchers noted in the *Journal of the American Geriatrics Society*. Clinicians can facilitate those discussions by starting the dialogue early—for instance, by suggesting their patient and someone they trust fill out an advance driving directive—and by using knowledge from guides to probe patients' driving abilities.

Published Online: August 2, 2023.
doi:10.1001/jama.2023.13617



iStock.com/Willowpix

Case of Middle East Respiratory Syndrome Coronavirus Confirmed

A person in the United Arab Emirates (UAE) recently tested positive for Middle East respiratory syndrome coronavirus (MERS-CoV), after being hospitalized, the World Health Organization (WHO) announced in a statement. No other cases have been identified, the WHO said.

MERS-CoV, a zoonotic virus transmitted from dromedary camels to humans, often causes symptoms including fever, cough, and shortness of breath that can range from mild to severe. About 35% of the 2605 people who have been infected worldwide have died—although that number might overestimate the fatality rate, the WHO said. Treatment for MERS-CoV infection involves supportive care.

The case is the first in the UAE since November 2021 and the country's 94th case overall since 2013. Because the current patient has no history of contact with camels, hadn't consumed raw camel products, and had no contact with another human with MERS-CoV, the WHO emphasized the importance of analyzing their virus' genome to identify anything unusual about its genetic evolution.

Published Online: August 2, 2023.
doi:10.1001/jama.2023.13618

Higher Levels of Omega-3 Fatty Acids Linked to Improved Lung Health

Omega-3 fatty acids, nutrients with anti-inflammatory properties that are available as dietary supplements as well as in foods such as fish, might protect against declines in lung health, results from a 2-part study published in the *American Journal of Respiratory and Critical Care Medicine* have shown.

Higher levels of omega-3 fatty acids in the bloodstream—particularly the fatty acid docosahexaenoic acid (DHA)—were linked with a slower rate of lung function decline in a longitudinal analysis of data from 15 063 participants. Higher DHA levels were also associated with a lower likelihood of restricted airflow from the lungs. The other analysis involving 500 000 UK Biobank participants used a technique known as mendelian randomization to probe a causal relationship between omega-3 fatty acid levels and lung health.

The study's results highlight the importance of including dietary omega-3 fatty acids, particularly because most people do not meet the current guidelines of consuming at least 2 servings of fish per week, the US National Institutes of Health, which sponsored the study, wrote in a statement.

Published Online: August 2, 2023.
doi:10.1001/jama.2023.13619

Private Equity Ownership in Health Care Linked to Higher Costs, Worse Quality

Private equity firms have increasingly used investors' funds to buy health care facilities and then sell them 3 to 7 years later for significant profit. Experts who are skeptical of private equity's growing role in health care have worried that the industry's focus on maximizing profit comes at a cost to patients and clinicians, but large-scale studies have been limited.

Now, a recent systematic review that included 55 studies from 8 countries concluded that not only has private equity ownership increased over time across many health care sectors, but it has also been linked with higher costs to patients or payers. Although results for the 27 studies that looked at health care quality were mixed, the researchers found evidence that private equity ownership was tied to worse quality in 21 of them compared with evidence of beneficial impact on quality in 12 studies.

© 2023 American Medical Association. All rights reserved.

Downloaded from jamanetwork.com by University of Chicago Libraries user on 03/08/2026

Finding solutions for quality problems linked with private equity ownership is challenging, a linked editorial noted. Efforts to encourage patients to visit higher-quality health care facilities by publicly posting hospital and nursing home ratings have had little effect. "For many communities in the US, the local hospital after a private equity takeover may be the only source of acute care," the author wrote in the *BMJ*.

Published Online: August 2, 2023.
doi:10.1001/jama.2023.13620

Orexin Agonist Effective but Not Safe in Narcolepsy Trial

A new treatment for narcolepsy improved people's ability to stay awake and reduced their weekly episodes of cataplexy, or sudden muscle weakness, compared with placebo, according to results from an 8-week clinical trial that included 73 participants. Currently, people with narcolepsy manage their condition with multiple medications that often do not control all their symptoms.

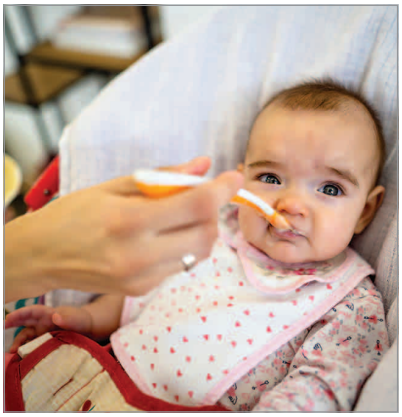
All participants had narcolepsy type 1, a condition defined by cataplexy symptoms and loss of neurons that produce orexin—a neuropeptide also known as hypocretin that binds to receptors in the brain to help people stay awake and alert. The drug used in the study was an orexin agonist.

The trial was terminated, however, because 8 participants experienced drug-induced liver damage. "Despite the halt in the development of [the drug], there is a strong rationale to pursue the use of orexin agonists for the treatment of narcolepsy type 1 and perhaps other disorders of hypersomnolence or circadian dislocation," the author of a linked editorial wrote in the *New England Journal of Medicine*.

Published Online: August 2, 2023.
doi:10.1001/jama.2023.13621

Pediatricians' Advice Is Major Factor in Early Peanut Introduction

Few parents or caregivers are aware of the 2017 national peanut allergy prevention guidelines that suggest introducing peanuts to infants early in life—as young as 4 to 6 months for high-risk infants, defined as those with an egg allergy, severe eczema, or both. Those who did know about the guidelines were more likely to be White, educated, or high income, or to care for an infant with a food allergy or eczema, according to results published in *Pediatrics* from 3062 people who responded to a national survey.



iStock.com/Viktorcvetkovic

Parents or caregivers whose pediatrician recommended introducing their infant to peanuts before 6 months were more likely to do so than those whose pediatrician did not. Moreover, the most common reason for waiting to introduce peanuts until their infant was older than 7 months was fear of triggering an allergic reaction—despite only 1.4% of parents or caregivers reporting one.

Published Online: August 2, 2023.
doi:10.1001/jama.2023.13622

Change in Medicare Policy Might Increase Colorectal Cancer Screening

Medicare coverage of computed tomography (CT) colonography might help reduce income-related disparities in beneficiaries' adherence to colorectal cancer screening guidelines, according to data from nearly 2.5 million adults enrolled in the Medicare fee-for-service program.

People living in wealthier communities were more likely than people from communities with per capita income below $25 000 to undergo colonoscopy and stool-based screening, although there was no difference between communities in the likelihood of undergoing sigmoidoscopy. In addition, people living in wealthier communities were more than 5 times more likely to have undergone screening CT colonography—a noninvasive procedure that requires no anesthesia but isn't covered by Medicare.

Although colonoscopies are considered the gold standard, the chance to choose other colorectal cancer screening methods can encourage people who might otherwise skip testing to get screened in a way that is less intrusive or carries a lower complication risk. Medicare's lack of coverage for CT colonography, therefore, might be linked to lower adherence to screening guidelines, the researchers wrote in the *American Journal of Roentgenology*.

Published Online: August 2, 2023.
doi:10.1001/jama.2023.13623

Study: Identifying Lewy Body Disease Before Symptoms

A reduced sense of smell and the presence in cerebrospinal fluid of α-synuclein, a protein that can aggregate to form the characteristic pathology of Lewy body disease, a type of dementia, was tied to later diagnosis with the condition, according to research published in *Nature Medicine* involving 1182 participants without cognitive or neurological impairment.

Drugs aimed at slowing Lewy body disease progression are in development and are most likely to be effective if given in the early stages of the condition. These findings could help identify eligible participants for clinical trials testing those early-intervention drugs, study author Oskar Hansson, MD, PhD, of Lund University in Sweden, said in a statement. **– Emily Harris**

Published Online: August 2, 2023.
doi:10.1001/jama.2023.13624

Note: Source references are available through embedded hyperlinks in the article text online.

© 2023 American Medical Association. All rights reserved.

Downloaded from jamanetwork.com by University of Chicago Libraries user on 03/08/2026